

No more bloatware

Corel Home Office is "optimised for netbooks", apparently: it weighs in at 100-ish MB, maximises screen space, and at \$70 (Rs 3500), is much cheaper than MS Office

Netpal

Disney and ASUS have partnered to release the Netpal—a netbook for kids—complete with a "unique Disney interface"

they're powering your game consoles, PMPs, Internet tablets, and smartphones.

So if the hardware doesn't belong either, where do we go from here?

Rethink

We already know what we expect netbooks to do properly: connect to the internet, run the essential office applications, and entertain in between.

On the software front, then, we want applications that are designed for small screens, don't hog resources, and still have the features we're used to. We also hope for cheap touchscreen netbooks in the future, so the interfaces also need to be finger-friendly.

This is where everything starts to sound oddly familiar. We've seen these things before, but nobody called them netbooks. They're already running operating systems and applications that are perfect for their small screens (some of which are touchscreens), and while they may not do movies, they do manage to let us use the web, get some office work done, and listen to some music. They're called PDAs and smartphones.

Maybe the ideal netbook isn't a shrunk desktop after all — maybe it's a pimped-out smartphone.

Perfect sense?

Apart from their ability to do nearly all the stuff we want to do with netbooks, there's a lot more to love about the smartphone. Because they've been small-screen devices forever, every application for a smartphone is designed with that screen in mind. The applications for touchscreen smartphones, too, are designed to be finger-friendly (well, the better applications, at least). The operating systems themselves are designed not to hog memory or processor cycles, much unlike the

systems we're using on netbooks right now.

And then, there's the hardware. Most smartphones and PDAs run on ARM-based processors, which are the mobile world's will-do-the-essentials-perfectly processors we just talked about. They're designed to consume as little power as possible, and can even include hardware tweaks to play movies and music better.

So if you take the innards of a smartphone, inject them with even more computing power, and stick them into the body of a current netbook, you might just get the netbook that should have been.

This isn't the dream of an annoyed writer, either — in the coming months, we'll see the netbook market slowly divide itself into the ARM-based and the x86-based.

In this corner...

The idea of an ARM-based netbook probably started with Google Android. It was the first Linux-based smartphone OS to see any real success, and when Linux meets success, it's widely regarded as a Good Thing®. Even though Android won't run standard Linux applications, it's probably the most mature avatar of Linux that runs on an ARM chip. Naturally, this begets the question "Can you call a really big Android phone a netbook?"

It's being answered.

Back in March, market research firm Ovum predicted that we'll see the first Android-powered netbooks later this year. At Computex in June, Qualcomm demonstrated a sleek little netbook based on ARM's Snapdragon chip—the same chip that powers the iPhone. A Chinese company called Guangzhou Skytone Transmission Technologies has already put up a product page for the Skytone Alpha 680, an Android-based netbook with a 7-inch touchscreen.

By next quarter, Freescale wants to push its own Android-based netbook onto the masses. And in Taiwan, an OEM has come up with a netbook that has both ARM and x86 chips — you'll run Android on the ARM, and Windows on the x86, should you miss the OS that much. The kicker? All these netbooks will cost less than \$250 (Rs 12,500).

And the ARM madness isn't just confined to Android, either. NVIDIA is now the proud parent of the Tegra, an ARM-based "system on a chip", which sticks a CPU, GPU, northbridge and southbridge into a tiny die, and is all set to power UMPCs running Windows Mobile or CE. And yes, it'll run Android too, if vendors want it to.

And yet, as ARM-based devices are set to make their big entrance, they might just trip over something silly — Adobe hasn't ported Flash to ARM yet, and since a sizable chunk of your internet experience involves your Flash

plugin, these devices may end up being non-starters.

Meanwhile...

The x86 camp isn't sitting idly by, either. Intel has been spearheading Moblin (short for Mobile Linux), a Linux desktop built for small screens, and optimised for the Atom. We've poked around in the beta, and it does address several of the issues we have with current operating systems. Instead of wasting space with irrelevant panels, it uses a simple tabbed interface at the top. Applications invariably occupy the whole screen, and have only the most essential buttons, giving you all the screen space possible.

All these features come with a rather pretty UI, powered by Clutter, a new user interface toolkit that uses OpenGL to deliver the "richness" we have come to desire from our interfaces. Under that, though, it's using GNOME Mobile, which means that unlike Android, it'll run regular Linux applications easily.

Moblin still has a way to go before it's truly usable — some parts of the interface are still the same old windows and it



The tiny NVIDIA Tegra started as a chip for Mobile Internet Devices (MIDs), but may soon power netbooks as well



Is the Android-based Alpha 680 the shape of things to come?

doesn't have a word processor yet, but with Intel pushing it strongly, this isn't over yet.

On the less exciting front, Ubuntu now comes in a "Netbook Remix" flavour, which also uses Clutter to make the interface better for small screens. However, apart from some minor tweaks, it's still the same interface underneath, which means you still lose pixels to unnecessarily large buttons, and other such frills.

But even as the platforms are evolving to make 7-inch screens usable once again, another problem rears its ugly head.